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**The return of Vijayan (l) and Achuthanandan to Politburo is meant to bolster the party for early polls.**

**MIFFED: Sonia's "no-alarm" remark in New York has angered some sections of the Left**

said W.R. Wardharajan, a CPI(M) Central Committee member.

But before CPI(M) finally decides to cut off the oxygen, it has to make a profit and loss statement of its own. Last weekend, the party's poll managers drew their estimates of Lok Sabha seats in West Bengal, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Tripura in the event of polls being held within the next six to eight months. While the party's state committees expressed some differences over the timing of the polls and the consequences thereof, unanimity prevailed over the nuclear agreement. The Central Committee held the view that endorsing the bilateral treaty in its current form would serve a body blow to Indian communism. "We cannot allow the US to use India for its strategic benefits in the subcontinent in the garb of this treaty," CPI(M) Politburo member M.K. Pandhe said.

The most obvious signal that the party was gearing up for early polls

came in the reinstatements of Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan and state's CPI(M) Secretary Pinarayi Vijayan, both suspended earlier this year for their personal feud which has seen the Kerala unit involved in a fratricidal war. Their sooner than expected reinduction is an acknowledgement that these two vote catchers are essential to the party.

**T**he Kerala unit reckons that factionalism could result in the loss of four to six Lok Sabha seats if elections were held early next year. Of the total of 43 CPI(M) members in the current Lok Sabha, Kerala's share is 12 while that of West Bengal is 26. Although West Bengal Chief Minister and CPI(M) Politburo member Buddhadeb Bhattacharjya's new age pragmatic Marxism is still to work wonders for his state, the Bengal Marxists seem to be confident that no political combination would be able to take away its vote percentage. According to the party's state unit, the worst case scenario could be a loss of not more than two to three seats even

if polls are held in May 2008.

CPI(M)'s campaign for the coming general elections would begin in November. That is when the party's state level conferences would also unfold as a run-up to its national congress in March-end next year. After the prime minister's dinner diplomacy with Bhattacharjya failed, foreign minister Pranab Mukherjee tried to open another line of communication with Marxist patriarch Jyoti Basu. While Mukherjee is probably the Left's only friend in Congress, his appeal was limited as Basu reportedly told him that the Left's position had already been articulated. With its core slogan of anti-imperialism, CPI(M) hopes to maintain its traditional votebank while the anti-communalism pitch would help it garner Muslim votes. It has, however, realised that fighting the Congress in a general election would take more than just the nuclear agreement. Pulling the rug would mean the Congress loses its government; but it doesn't necessarily mean that CPI(M) gains. ■